

CONCEPT PAPER · 1-YEAR PILOT

Land + Launch NWA

A Global Innovation Exchange Initiative

A one-year pilot connecting global and local founders to the industries that anchor Northwest Arkansas — commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation — and welcoming founders across geographies and backgrounds into the region. Administered by SEED SPOT. Delivered by Arkade.

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Executive Summary

Northwest Arkansas (NWA) sits at the center of one of the most concentrated industry ecosystems in the world, anchored by global headquarters spanning consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation. Innovation and entrepreneurship are no longer peripheral — they are essential drivers of competitiveness, resilience, and long-term growth across these industries.

While the region has made meaningful progress in supporting local early-stage entrepreneurs, a clear opportunity remains: intentionally connecting Bentonville's professional ecosystem with a broader, more diverse network of founders and cultural perspectives from around the world.

SEED SPOT, in partnership with Arkade, proposes a **one-year pilot initiative** to build that ecosystem by creating programming that connects global and local entrepreneurs — welcoming founders across geographies and backgrounds and helping them navigate an unfamiliar market — expands access to industry knowledge, and builds pathways for talent. Land + Launch NWA will be administered by SEED SPOT as fiduciary partner and delivered through Arkade's platform supporting founder engagement and ecosystem connectivity.

This effort will:

- Engage B2B technology startups, based globally and locally, serving commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation
- Connect founders and teams to NWA's industry ecosystem of mentors, advisors, leaders, talent, and partners
- Strengthen regional innovation programming and gatherings open to cohort participants and the broader community
- Expand access to opportunity for founders, students, and workforce participants in Northwest Arkansas
- Elevate Bentonville's national and global profile as a hub for applied industry innovation and talent

We are seeking **\$973,000** in grant funding, matched by approximately **\$521,000** in in-kind contributions from Arkade — primarily dedicated workspace and staff — for a total program investment of approximately **\$1.5 million** over the one-year pilot. Grant funding will support four key components: Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning, Partnership Engagement and Cohort Curation, Innovation Programming and Industry Gatherings, and Talent and Ecosystem Integration.

The Challenge: Opportunity Without Connection

Northwest Arkansas (NWA) is home to one of the most concentrated industry ecosystems in the world. Five global headquarters anchor the region's core industries — consumer commerce (Walmart, Sam's Club), food and agriculture (Tyson Foods, Simmons Foods), and logistics and transportation (J.B. Hunt) — alongside more than 1,100 CPG brand offices. Three rank in the Fortune 500, and combined annual revenue from NWA-headquartered companies exceeds **\$750 billion** — more than the GDP of metropolitan Boston. For a region of just over 600,000 residents, that's a rare concentration of industry.

Yet the two-way exchange between this local ecosystem and the global innovation community remains limited, leaving founders, students, decision makers, and higher education institutions without consistent channels of access.

How this plays out today:

- Companies from outside the region conduct cold outreach or visit Bentonville for 1–2 days of meetings, then leave
- Introductions are made informally, without structure or sustained follow-through
- No formalized programming connects founders to workspace, pilot opportunities, regulatory navigation, or workforce
- High-growth companies default to Austin, Atlanta, New York, and Toronto — ecosystems that actively attract and integrate them

Entrepreneurs — many building across geographies and from different cultural backgrounds — often face challenges in accessing:

- Warm introductions and relationship-building access to local industry leadership
- Coordinated entry points into the regional talent ecosystem
- Support navigating cultural and market differences when entering an unfamiliar region — building local trust, understanding regional business culture, and establishing a presence far from home networks
- Opportunities to engage with applied innovation at scale and peers building across geographies

Students and early-career professionals locally would benefit from increased access to:

- Hands-on experience with innovation-driven companies
- Exposure to emerging technologies and entrepreneurial pathways
- Networking access to local business and commercial leadership

Without intentional channels for innovation, knowledge, and talent exchange, the region risks underutilizing its full innovation potential. When global and local builders and decision makers connect through Land + Launch NWA, everyone in the community wins through employment, idea exchange, and ecosystem growth.

The Solution: Land + Launch NWA

Program Overview

Land + Launch NWA is a **one-year pilot** supporting a cohort of growth-stage B2B technology companies building in Northwest Arkansas' anchor industries: consumer commerce, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation. **Growth-stage** is defined here as companies at Series A+ with demonstrated product-market fit in their native markets.

The six-month cohort program offers **six to 12 startup companies** support through transition and cultural education, a home-based work site with built-in industry-related peers, and access to top leaders and students through events and programming.

Participating companies benefit from:

- Targeted, personalized introductions to ecosystem partners, mentors, investors, and industry leaders
- Programming, workshops, and learning opportunities across commerce enablement, food, and logistics
- Engagement with student talent and higher public education institutions
- A dedicated desk and physical workspace at Arkade in the Ledger Building
- Legal, regulatory, and relocation navigation through Arkade's advisory board and ecosystem partners

Target Company Profile

- A mix of founders building from outside the region (75%) and Northwest Arkansas-based founders building for anchor industries (25%)
- B2B technology companies in NWA's anchor industries — commerce enablement, food and agriculture, logistics and transportation, AI and data analytics, automation and robotics, and sustainability and packaging
- Series A+ with demonstrated product-market fit, revenue generating or in late-stage pilot phase
- Capacity to hire locally within 12 months
- Companies actively seeking to engage with the NWA ecosystem

Pilot Timeline (12 Months)

Land + Launch NWA runs as a 12-month pilot. The six-month cohort program sits within that year, with dedicated time to stand the program up at the front and to evaluate and plan forward at the close.

PHASE 1 · ESTABLISH

Months 1–3

Hire the Program & Education Manager and Communications Director, formalize the SEED SPOT–Arkade structure, build partnerships and ecosystem intelligence, and begin sourcing the cohort.

PHASE 2 · COHORT PROGRAM

Months 4–12

Companies onboard on a rolling basis across Months 4–6, each receiving the full six-month program of transition support, programming, gatherings, and ecosystem introductions.

PHASE 3 · EVALUATE

Months 10–12

Capture outcomes, report to funders and partners, and assess what a continued program would look like beyond the pilot.

Four Pillars of Programming

01 Ecosystem Intelligence and Strategic Positioning

THE FOUNDATION LAYER

Strengthen understanding of the regional innovation landscape and identify opportunities for the exchange of innovation, knowledge, and talent — connecting global founders, local entrepreneurs, students, and industry.

- Subscribe to research, sourcing, and network tools (data subscriptions)
 - Conduct ecosystem mapping and landscape analysis across NWA's anchor industries
 - Develop sector-specific insights across commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation
 - Identify and map founders and investors; maintain impact dashboarding and reporting
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02 Partnership Engagement and Cohort Curation

THE ENGAGEMENT LAYER

Connect with global and local founder networks and bring high-potential founders into the Northwest Arkansas innovation ecosystem experience — building cohorts that strengthen mutual exchange between the region and the broader innovation community.

- Source, engage, and curate the cohort from global and local founder networks
 - Cultivate partnerships across regional organizations and institutions (i.e., form a local Brand Leadership Council)
 - Engage partners from embassy, trade, and accelerators; connect with higher education networks and global innovation communities
 - Perform targeted outreach campaigns across commerce enablement, food, and logistics channels
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Four Pillars of Programming

03 Innovation Programming and Industry Gatherings

THE COLLABORATION LAYER

Create consistent opportunities for the exchange of innovation, knowledge, and talent — bringing global founders, local entrepreneurs, students, and industry leaders together for learning, collaboration, and ecosystem participation.

Grant-supported Activities

- **Coffee Shop at Arkade** (bi-weekly) — Open coffee meetups connecting cohort founders with local entrepreneurs, students, and the community for informal networking.
 - **Industry Education Workshops** (monthly) — Curated 10-person lunches and workshops on demand-driven innovation across commerce enablement, food, and logistics.
 - **BiteSized Conference** (quarterly) — Closed-door, curated discussions between founders, enterprise executives, and investors focused on partnership and ecosystem alignment.
 - **NWA Tech Summit Activation** (annually) — A high-visibility Arkade-hosted activation or VIP industry dinner around applied innovation in NWA's anchor industries.
 - **Market Immersion Week** (1× each company) — A two- to three-day welcome itinerary with team orientation, warm intro meetings to local leaders or potential customers, and tours.
 - **Relationship Curation** (throughout program) — Connections to industry leaders, enterprise partners, investors, and talent across the cohort experience.
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04 Talent and Ecosystem Integration

THE COMPOUNDING LAYER

Expand access for Northwest Arkansas students, early-career professionals, and workforce to engage with growth-stage innovation, while helping cohort companies build enduring local roots.

Grant-supported Activities

- **Innovation Fellows** — paid internships placing up to eight Northwest Arkansas students and early-career professionals (four per semester, across two semesters) inside cohort and Arkade member companies for hands-on exposure to growth-stage innovation
 - **Education partnerships** — collaboration with the University of Arkansas, Northwest Arkansas Community College, and other institutions on talent pathways, guest programming, and curriculum input
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Governance & Measurable Outcomes

Governance & Structure

To ensure compliance, transparency, and alignment with philanthropic best practices, SEED SPOT will serve as the initiative's fiduciary, administering all grant funds and ensuring they are allocated strictly toward approved programmatic activities. Arkade will serve as program delivery partner under a formal agreement. Together, the partners will establish clear KPIs with quarterly reporting and produce an annual public impact report, so that progress and the use of funds remain transparent throughout the pilot.

SEED SPOT leads on:

- Grant administration, fiduciary oversight, and compliance
- Alignment with philanthropic best practices and shared mission
- Access to a trusted national network of entrepreneurs, mentors, and partners
- Final program reporting and outcome tracking, with supporting information from Arkade

Arkade leads on:

- Program delivery and founder engagement
- Cohort sourcing and engagement strategy execution
- Company relationship management
- Regional ecosystem alignment, partnerships, and introductions
- Community engagement, and program data and information to support reporting

Measurable Outcomes

The pilot will track clear outcomes across direct program and ecosystem engagement, with quarterly reporting to SEED SPOT.

Program and Ecosystem Engagement

- 6–12 growth-stage companies supported through the inaugural cohort
- 60+ ecosystem introductions facilitated, including connections to advisors, operators, mentors, talent, and potential partners
- 40+ programming touchpoints with entrepreneurs across workshops, coffee meetups, conferences, and gatherings open to the broader community
- Up to 8 students placed through the Innovation Fellows program
- 1–2 educational partnerships established with regional institutions (e.g., University of Arkansas, Northwest Arkansas Community College) for internship pipelines, guest programming, and career pathway exposure for students

These outcomes focus on strengthening participation, expanding access to opportunity, and deepening ecosystem connectivity across Northwest Arkansas.

Budget & Cost Share

Budget Overview (12-Month Pilot)

\$973K Grant Request	\$521K Arkade In-Kind Match (workspace + staff)	\$1.49M Total Program Budget
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The grant funds program delivery directly; Arkade contributes a substantial in-kind match — primarily dedicated workspace and staff time — bringing the total program value to approximately \$1.5 million.

Major Budget Categories

- Personnel:** Program & Education Manager and Communications Director (the two-person program team) · full Director and staff allocation (Arkade in-kind) · contracted event logistics
- Program Infrastructure:** Dedicated workspace at Arkade (in-kind) · software and data tools · marketing and outreach
- Events & Education:** Bi-weekly Coffee Shop at Arkade · monthly Industry Education Workshops · quarterly BiteSized conferences · Bentonville Market Immersion Weeks · NWA Tech Summit activation · Innovation Fellows · speaker and advisor honoraria
- Travel & Transition Support:** Inbound travel for speakers and cohort companies · outbound travel for key industry events · founder legal and immigration support (entity formation and visa navigation)
- Administration:** Program administration and reporting · contingency · fiscal oversight through SEED SPOT (approximately 10% of program cost)

Cost Share and Beyond the Pilot

This is a one-year pilot. The grant of \$973,000 funds program delivery, and Arkade contributes approximately \$521,000 in in-kind workspace and staff — roughly one in-kind dollar for every two grant dollars — for a total program investment of about \$1.5 million.

A successful pilot creates the foundation to grow — toward a sustained, multi-cohort program supported by a mix of continued philanthropic investment, earned revenue, corporate sponsorship, and ecosystem support. The pilot year is designed to prove the model and to define what scaling responsibly looks like.

The Partnership and Why This Matters Now

| The Partnership

Two organizations. Each essential. One shared mission.

This initiative is delivered through a partnership between SEED SPOT and Arkade. The roles are distinct and complementary.

FIDUCIARY & NATIONAL PARTNER

SEED SPOT

A national nonprofit that supports diverse entrepreneurs — across geographies and backgrounds — and serves as the fiduciary for the initiative. SEED SPOT brings a trusted national network of founders, mentors, and partners, a mission centered on expanding access to entrepreneurship, and an established 501(c)(3) structure for administering philanthropic programs.

PROGRAM DELIVERY PARTNER

Arkade

A platform supporting founder engagement and ecosystem connectivity in Northwest Arkansas. Its work focuses on connecting global and local founders to the region's innovation ecosystem — and connecting the region's entrepreneurs to the broader global innovation community. Arkade provides workspace and access to advisors, industry leaders, and partners.

Together, these partners contribute trusted national infrastructure and local, private-sector execution. Philanthropic investment makes the work possible — supporting participation, access to opportunity, and connection across Northwest Arkansas.

| Why This Matters Now

Northwest Arkansas stands at a pivotal moment. The region offers a rare concentration of global industry leadership across commerce enablement, food and agriculture, and logistics and transportation, alongside major CPG presence, a growing talent pool, rapid population growth, supportive regional civic leadership, and national visibility.

Over time, this initiative makes Northwest Arkansas a community where innovation, knowledge, and talent move freely between global and local founders, students, and industry — strengthening the region for the long term.

Land + Launch NWA is the bridge that makes those connections possible.